Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Resources in Toronto: Methodology

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Research Methodology

I will use a qualitative methodology to explore how newcomer families at one Toronto child care centre learn about, understand, and use or do not use the family support resources that the centre offers or refers families to, which in this study means services such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON, and settlement services. Qualitative research studies a small number of participants in depth, so that the researcher can gather detailed accounts of one central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). This depth suits my central question, which asks how newcomer families describe their experiences of accessing and using or not using these resources. A family's path to a resource has many small steps, such as reading a notice, asking an educator, or deciding, at some point, that a form is too hard. A count of fee subsidy applications could tell me what families did, but not how they understood the information, who helped them, or why they stopped where they did, and these details, which open conversations can bring out, are exactly what my central question asks about.

Context is the second reason for this choice. Qualitative researchers pay close attention to the context that shapes participants' experiences (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019), and for the families in this study, that context includes how the centre shares information about resources, whether the information is in a language they can read, which referrals staff make, and what each application asks a family to provide. Families meet these conditions in different languages, after different migration journeys, so I will describe them alongside the families' accounts. Because parents describe this context in their own words, an interview on Zoom or by phone can still collect it, although these formats give fewer non-verbal cues than an in-person meeting. To reduce this limitation, I will ask parents to walk me through specific moments, for example the first time they read a notice, or the day they sat down to fill out a form.

The third reason is meaning-making. Grounded in constructivism, qualitative research seeks to understand how people make meaning of their social realities (Mwita, 2022). This matters here, because newcomer parents' perspectives are often not accounted for, in research or in the way services are planned and explained, and a word like eligibility, or waitlist, may mean one thing to a parent and something else to an educator. How a family interprets such information shapes whether it uses a resource. Open-ended interview questions will let me hear how each family makes sense of eligibility rules and educators' explanations, and how it reaches a decision, and since families may understand the same rules in different ways, these differences will add depth to the data.

Research Design

I will use a qualitative descriptive design, which aims to give a full summary of events in the everyday language of the people who experienced them (Sandelowski, 2000). Researchers who use it stay close to what participants say, keeping interpretation low, so the findings reflect participants' own words more than the researcher's. The design also studies experiences in their natural setting, without variables or a theory chosen in advance (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024).

This design fits my study for three reasons. First, because qualitative description reports events in the words of the people who experienced them (Sandelowski, 2000), I can organize my interview protocol around the steps families take with a resource, from hearing about it, to working out what it requires, to deciding whether to use it. My sub-questions ask what helped or limited families, who explained the steps, and how educators responded to their language and cultural needs. Since the analysis will stay close to what parents say, the findings can follow the same steps, and each part of the findings can then answer one of these questions directly. Second, qualitative description suits studies that need information directly from the people affected but have limited time and resources (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024), and a single-centre student project, completed within one term, fits that description. Third, findings that stay close to participants' words can inform practice (Villamin et al., 2025). Educators at the centre could use them to see where their explanations and referrals help families, and where they fall short. Ilumin (2023) used the same design, with immigrant families in Edmonton, to describe their child care experiences.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

The participants will be four newcomer parents or primary caregivers. I define a newcomer family as an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant must (a) be 18 or older, (b) have arrived in Canada within the past five years, in any immigration category, (c) have a child enrolled at the study centre, (d) have received information about, or a referral to, at least one family support service from the centre in the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON, or settlement services, and (e) be able to take part in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

These criteria select parents with direct and recent experience with accessing and utilizing the resources my questions ask about. Criterion (d) includes parents whether or not they went on to use the resource, because my research question asks about both using and not using resources. I will explore each family's account on its own terms. The study will not divide families into users and non-users, and it will not compare them.

I will exclude families I have worked with in the past, including families from the room where I completed my placement, and families of centre staff. My earlier role, or a parent's employment at the centre, could make these families feel obliged to take part or less willing to speak critically about the centre (Villamin et al., 2025). Because I define newcomers by their time in Canada, eligibility will not depend on immigration category. Permanent residents, refugees and refugee claimants, parents with work or study permits, and parents who became citizens within the past five years will all be eligible, because immigration status can affect eligibility for services such as the fee subsidy, for example through tax-filing requirements (Toronto Children's Services, 2025), and these differences are part of what families experience. I will also not ask about immigration status. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents that undocumented families often cannot provide (Schmidt, 2026), and questions about status could discourage families from joining.

Recruitment Setting

I will recruit at a licensed child care centre in the Parkdale neighbourhood of west Toronto, the centre where I completed my field placement, and to protect families' privacy, I will not name it

in this proposal or in any report. I chose this setting for two reasons. First, the centre already offers and refers family support resources, so its families have the experiences my questions ask about, and Toronto's service plan names child care settings as access points while also identifying tax-filing requirements as a barrier to fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025). A study in one centre can therefore show how these city policies reach families. Second, my placement gives me access to the centre, which makes recruitment feasible within the course timeline.

Recruitment Methods

I will first obtain approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022), along with written permission from the centre director, and I will not contact any family before both are in place. I will then prepare a one-page flyer and a letter of information, written in plain English and translated into Mandarin and other languages common at the centre. These materials will explain the purpose of the study, the total time, about 60 to 75 minutes in one meeting, the voluntary nature of taking part, the $25 gift card, and how to reach me. The gift card is meant to recognize the time the meeting asks of each parent. TCPS 2 asks researchers to consider participants' economic circumstances, so that an incentive does not become an undue inducement (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022), and Head (2009) notes that payment in qualitative research can recognize participants' time while also raising concerns about its influence on consent. For this reason I chose a modest amount, and the card will not depend on completing the interview, since parents who skip questions, or stop early, will still receive it. The Research Ethics Board will also review the amount before recruitment begins.

The director will share the invitation through the parent newsletter, the notice board, and family cubbies, while staff will not approach families in person. As in Hardware et al. (2026), someone other than the lead researcher will distribute the invitation, to avoid a conflict of interest. Still, a notice from the director could feel like a request from the centre, so the flyer will state that the centre will not know who takes part, and that the decision will not affect any child's care. Interested parents will contact me directly, by email, phone, or text, and a 10-minute call will confirm eligibility. Parents will have at least 48 hours to decide after they receive the consent form. If fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1, the director will send one reminder.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. I will use purposive sampling, in which the researcher intentionally selects people who can help to understand the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019), and here that means newcomer parents who have received information about, or a referral to, a family support service from the centre. The sample will also be a convenience sample, because I will recruit willing and available parents at a centre I can already reach (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). In other words, the purposive criteria decide who is eligible, and convenience explains where I will find them. Neither method aims to represent all newcomer families, but together they reach parents who can give detailed accounts of accessing and using resources through this centre.

Participant Selection. Parents will contact me voluntarily, and during the 10-minute eligibility call, I will screen each one against the inclusion and exclusion criteria. The centre will not take part in screening or selection, and it will not be told who responded. Eligible parents will receive the letter of information and consent form, in their preferred language, before they decide. I will select the first four eligible parents who agree to take part, with only one adult from each family. If more than four respond, the others will go on a waitlist, in order of contact, and I will invite them in turn if a participant withdraws before the interview.

Sample Size. I will include four participants, which matches the course requirement for individual projects. Qualitative studies commonly use about four to eight participants, a size that lets the researcher explore each person's experience in detail (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The findings will describe these four families' experiences, and they will not be generalized to all newcomer families.

Data Collection

Procedure

I will collect data through individual, semi-structured, in-depth interviews, with the interview as my data collection method and an interview protocol as my tool. The protocol will list open-ended questions, each with follow-up probes, and because its order is flexible, I can ask for more detail when a parent raises something new. I chose individual interviews over focus groups. Income and subsidy are sensitive topics, and families at one centre may know one another (Villamin et al., 2025).

Before Week 1, I will pilot the protocol with one newcomer parent from outside the study, checking its wording, translation, and length.

Each participant will take part in one meeting, about 60 to 75 minutes long, at a time the family chooses. Families can meet in a private room at the centre, outside drop-off and pick-up times, or join on Zoom or by phone, and those who join online may turn off the camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). I will interview Mandarin speakers myself. For other languages, a trained interpreter, who signs a confidentiality agreement, will join so that meaning is not lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). Each meeting will follow three steps:

1. **Consent (about 10 minutes).** I will go through the letter of information with the parent, in their language, and answer any questions, after which the parent will sign the consent form or give recorded verbal consent.
2. **Background form (about 5 minutes).** On this short form, the parent will note years in Canada, children's ages, home language, and the services the centre shared information about or referred them to, but not immigration status or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** With permission, I will audio record the interview, and the questions will follow the steps families take toward a resource. Parents will describe how they learned about a resource, what they understood about eligibility and applying, and who helped them, whether educators, settlement workers, or relatives, as well as what that help involved. They will then talk about what led them to use or not use the resource. Finally, I will ask whether they could raise needs linked to their language and culture, how educators responded, and what they would suggest the centre change. At the end, each parent will receive the $25 gift card, along with a list of community supports such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.

Taking part is voluntary. Parents may skip any question, or stop the interview at any time, and will still receive the gift card, and they may withdraw their data within one week after their interview, before I begin coding it, without any effect on their child's care. I will remove names, use pseudonyms, and keep recordings and transcripts in encrypted, password-protected files stored apart from the consent forms, with only me holding the list that links pseudonyms to names. Because a

small sample from one centre can make people identifiable, my reports will not combine details such as country of origin and home language, and I will change or leave out any quotation that could identify a family (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Obtain ethics approval and the director's permission, translate materials, and pilot the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Invitation shared by the director, one reminder if needed, screening calls, consent, and interviews booked
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	First interviews in Week 2, at least three of four (75%) done by the end of Week 3, each one transcribed soon after
Week 4	Complete data collection	Last interview, then initial coding begins
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Summary of preliminary findings submitted
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Complete semantic-level thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022) and submit the findings report by Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Findings reviewed and refined, using feedback
Week 10	Presentation draft	Presentation drafted
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Presentation and final report revised
Week 14	Final submission	Final report submitted

Ethics approval must be in place before the term begins, since recruitment starts in Week 1 and the first interviews follow in Week 2. Each interview will be transcribed soon after it ends, which lets me start coding in Week 4 and have preliminary findings ready for Week 5. Throughout the study, I will keep a reflexive journal of decisions, changes, and challenges, as they happen.

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